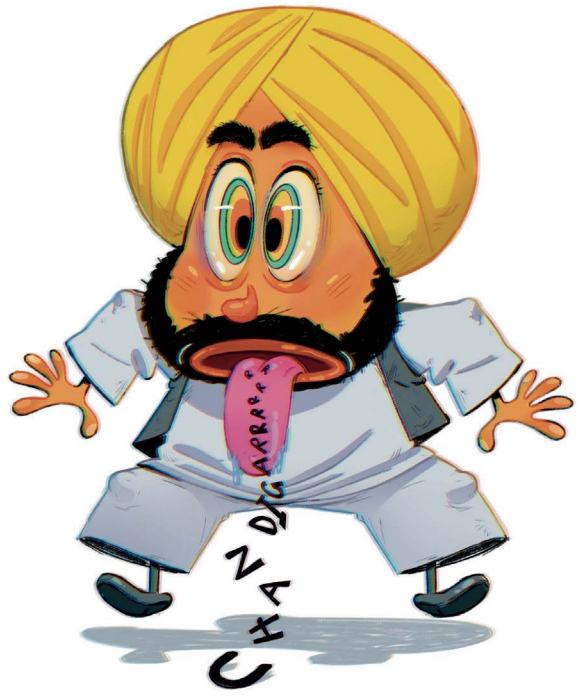


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

SPELLCHECK GONE ROGUE

All Punjab chief minister Bhagwant S. Mann wanted to do was to take a swing at his opponents, only to hit himself square in the face. Mocking the elite, Anglicised lifestyle of some of the state's political leaders, he wondered if they could even spell Chandigarh in Punjabi. He proceeded to do so himself, except that he mangled both the spelling and the pronunciation of the state capital. The joke soon turned on him, as BJP's Subhash Sharma reminded him of the wisdom of '*tol mol ke bol*' or weighing words before speaking, and Congress's Pratap Bajwa wondered how someone could fail their own quiz. Akali Dal's Bikram Majithia couldn't resist raking up his past as standup comic, asking him to observe the fine line between "the state and stage". One routine that clearly bombed.



Secret Campaign

West Bengal BJP leader **Dilip Ghosh**, known for his media-friendly ways, has been avoiding journalists lately. Instead, he has been suspiciously busy crisscrossing the state, sparking a flurry of rumours. Party insiders are puzzled why Ghosh, who currently holds no electoral or organisational position in the BJP, is touring and meeting with party workers. Meanwhile, state BJP president Sukanta Majumdar has been inducted into the Union ministry. Could it be that Ghosh, Majumdar's predecessor, is eyeing a return to the chair?

POWER SHIFT



The centre of power is poised for a shift in Gujarat, as 71-year-old ex-bureaucrat **K. Kailashnathan** steps down as chief principal secretary to the chief minister. Often referred to as the 'super CM', KK had held this position since 2013, when he retired. He had first joined the Narendra Modi CMO in 2006, and had become the prime minister's trusted confidant in Gujarat, acting as a vital link between the state's political apparatus and its powerful bureaucracy. Now that he has exited, KK is likely to be succeeded by another set of ex-bureaucrats, Hasmukh Adhia and S.S. Rathore, who were appointed as advisors to the CM.



Saunik Boom

Maharashtra may be regarded as a progressive state and a pioneer in feminist movements but it has taken it decades to get its first woman chief secretary. **Sujata Saunik,** a 1987 batch IAS officer, will occupy that post after the superannuation of incumbent Dr Nitin Kareer. Incidentally, Sujata's husband, Manoj, was also the state chief secretary and, in fact, Kareer's predecessor. Talk about being a power couple!

EXPENSIVE BOAST

Even as the NDA government at the Centre faces the heat on NEET, its ally in Uttar Pradesh, the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP), is making things worse. Videos have surfaced of one of its first-time MLAs, **Bedi Ram,** from the Jakhania assembly seat, bragging about his ability to "facilitate recruitment" to government positions in lieu of money. In the clips, Bedi can be heard claiming he can arrange "40 recruitments at a time". In another video, he appears to be mediating a financial dispute between two groups following the cancellation of an exam. SBSP chief and UP minister O.P. Rajbhar met Union home minister Amit Shah and BJP president J.P. Nadda to offer an explanation, but insiders say it may not suffice.



Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Jumana Shah, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Prashant Srivastava